CHAPTER 6

Delivering Instruction

Eliciting Responses

In Chapter 2, we have introduced a lesson design that includes an opening, a body, and a closing. However, even when you have crafted an exquisite, well-structured lesson or adopted a curriculum material with explicit lessons of high quality, it is still possible that some students may not be totally riveted to your every word or deeply processing the lesson content. Student attention and subsequent learning depend not only on the design of lessons, but also on the delivery of those lessons. Analogously, if a wonderful movie script is not delivered by talented actors, the resulting movie is likely to bomb at the box office.

In Chapter 1, four essential delivery skills have been introduced as part of the 16 elements of explicit instruction (see Figure 1.1):

1. Require frequent responses.
2. Monitor student performance carefully.
3. Provide immediate affirmative and corrective feedback.
4. Deliver the lesson at a brisk pace.

Whether you are teaching a large or small group, you must elicit **frequent responses** by requiring students to say, write, and/or do things. If instruction is truly interactive and students are constantly responding, then attention, on-task behavior, and learning increase, and behavioral challenges decrease. Similarly, you should maximize the amount of reading practice students engage in during instructional time, particularly when you are working with beginning readers or older struggling readers. Achieving maximum amounts of reading necessitates using alternative procedures to round-robin reading, especially in large-group settings. Effective instruction also requires constant **monitoring** of student responses, so that you

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can give high-quality **feedback** (including corrections and affirmations) and can modify the lesson based on student performance. Finally, throughout the lesson, you need to maintain a **pace** of instruction that engages students and optimizes the amount of content covered without sacrificing adequate thinking time. The following diagram illustrates the relationship of these delivery skills.



As you read this chapter, you may wish to stop and teach the example lessons. This "virtual teaching" will bring the chapter alive and help you transfer the delivery skills to your own teaching. If you incorporate the suggested practices into your current teaching, student teaching, or tutoring, these skills will soon be a part of your own repertoire. You probably already possess many of these skills, so be sure to acknowledge their existence as you read.

REQUIRE FREQUENT RESPONSES

The delivery skill most fundamental to explicit instruction is the eliciting of frequent student responses. Because of its importance, we focus in the remainder of this chapter on how to elicit frequent responses and how to use reading procedures that will maximize student engagement. The remaining delivery skills are covered in Chapter 7.

When eliciting frequent responses, a teacher presents a little information and then stops to ask for a response from students. Then the teacher repeats this pattern again and again, thus giving the students many opportunities to respond: **Input → Question → Response. Input → Question → Response. Input → Question → Response. Input → Question → Response**. Like good conversation, good instruction is interactive; it is not **Input → Input → Input → Input → Input → See you tomorrow**. In this latter condition, even the most motivated student would be tempted to "check out" and go into deep cognitive "floating." Giving students many opportunities to respond during a lesson has many proven benefits (e.g., Brophy & Good, 1986; Cavanaugh, Heward, & Donelson, 1996; Greenwood, Hart, Walker, & Risley, 1994; Skinner, Fletcher, & Henington, 1996). Students, of course, are more attentive and on task. More importantly, in the act of responding, students are retrieving, rehearsing, and practicing the information, concepts, skills, or strategies being taught, thereby increasing the probability of retention. In addition, through monitoring of student responses, you can check the clarity of your teaching and adjust the lesson as needed: reteaching critical information, clearing up any misconceptions, or moving ahead in the lesson. You can also provide corrective feedback to the group or individual when errors occur, thus reducing the discrepancy between current understanding or performance and the desired outcome. Increasing opportunities to respond also increases the opportunities for

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acknowledging correct responses and for task-focused praise, which are particularly beneficial to students with learning or emotional challenges (Gunter, Denny, Jack, Shores, & Nelson, 1993). Finally, if students are actively engaged and successful, behavioral challenges will be reduced. As Sutherland and Wehby (2001) concluded in their review of related research, higher opportunities to respond result in higher task engagement, higher academic achievement, and lower rates of inappropriate behavior.

Although there are many ways to request responses during a lesson, we outline a number of procedures that we have found particularly effective and easy to implement across settings and content areas. We emphasize **unison responding**, in which all students respond, rather than the traditional procedure in which the teacher asks a question, students raise their hands, and the teacher calls on a volunteer. Unison responding (e.g., saying an answer together, writing an answer on a response slate and holding it up, or holding up a response card) has been shown to increase not only the number of responses given by each student, but on-task behavior and academic attainment (Hamlin, Lee, & Ruhl, 2008; Heward, 1997). We have organized the responses according to the behaviors of the students: (1) oral responses, (2) written responses, and (3) action responses. As you read through these procedures, identify the ones that you already use and ones that you could add to your repertoire.

Oral Responses

The most common responses requested in lessons at any grade level are oral. There are a number of practices for eliciting oral responses that have particular promise: choral responses, partner responses, team responses, and carefully designed individual responses.

Choral Responses

Whether you are teaching math, reading, science, or social studies, there are times when the oral answers you request are short and the wording is the same across learners. In special or general education, or in elementary or secondary classes, when the answer is short and there is only one correct answer, all students can be asked to say the answer together. **Choral responding** has proven to be a flexible procedure that is adaptable across grades and content for increasing the frequency of student responses and subsequent learning (e.g., Hamlin et al., 2008; Heward, Courson, & Narayan, 1989; Wood & Heward, 2005). Choral responses can be interspersed throughout lessons, but are particularly powerful when used to practice or review factual information. Examine the lesson segments in Figure 6.1 to see how choral responses can be elicited in different settings. Read the lesson from left to right to see the flow of **Input** → **Question** → **Response** → **Monitor** → **Feedback**. As you read all of the lessons in this chapter, give special attention to the **feedback** provided after student responses. Desirable attributes of feedback are discussed in Chapter 7.

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FIGURE 6.1. Lesson segments: Choral responses.

Lesson segment 1: Beginning reading				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
On the board: *s*, *a*, *m*, *t*				
Let's review some sounds. When I touch under a letter, say its sound.	[Teacher touches under *s*.] What sound? [Teacher signals for response.]	/*s*/.	[Teacher listens carefully. All students say the correct sound.]	[Teacher moves on with no comment.]
	[Teacher touches under *a*.] What sound? [Teacher signals for response.]	/*ă*/.	[Teacher listens carefully. Two students say /*ŏ*/.]	[Teacher points to *a*.] This sound is /*ă*/. What sound? [Teacher signals.] /*ă*/. [Teacher points to *s*.] What sound? [Teacher signals.] /*s*/. [Teacher points to *a*.] What sound? [Teacher signals.] /*ă*/.
[Teacher continues with remaining letters and then reviews them in random order.]			[Teacher listens carefully. All students say all sounds correctly.]	Great.
Lesson segment 2: Fifth-grade math				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
On the board: x + 5 = 15				
Look at this equation.	What is the unknown variable? [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals for response.]	*x*.	[Teacher listens carefully. All students respond correctly.]	[Teacher moves on, indicating a correct response.]
	To isolate x, should we add or subtract 5 from each side? [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals for response.]	*Subtract 5.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	Yes, in order to isolate x, we must subtract 5 from each side.
	[Teacher writes x + 5 – 5 =]. If we subtract 5 from this side of the equation, what is left? [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals for response.]	*x*.	[Teacher listens carefully.]	[Teacher writes x below x + 5 – 5.]

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	[Teacher writes 15 – 5.] If we subtract 5 from this side of the equation, what is left? [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals.] Everyone, what is the value of x? [Teacher signals.]	*10.* *10.*	[Teacher listens carefully.] [Teacher listens carefully.]	[Teacher writes 10 below 15 – 5.] Let's check the answer by replacing x with 10. What is 10 plus 5? [Teacher signals.] *15.* Both sides are equal to 15. So x does equal 10.
Lesson segment 3: Seventh-grade science				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
On an overhead transparency: *shield volcano*, *composite volcano*, *cinder cone volcano*				
We have been studying three types of volcanoes. I will tell you about one type of volcano. You tell me which one I am thinking about.	This type of volcano has very steep sides. [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals.]	*Composite volcano.*	[Teacher listens carefully. All students respond correctly.]	Yes, composite volcanoes have steep sides.
	This type of volcano has low-sloping sides. [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals.]	*Shield volcano.*	[Teacher listens carefully. All students respond correctly.]	True, shield volcanoes, like the volcanoes of Hawaii that we looked at yesterday, have low-sloping sides.
	This type of volcano has layers of lava and ash. [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals.]	*Composite volcano.*	[Teacher listens carefully. Many students don't respond correctly.]	Remember, *composite* means "made from more than one material." Composite volcanoes have layers of lava and ash. Everyone, volcanoes with layers of lava and ash are _____? [Teacher signals.] *Composite volcanoes.*
	This type of volcano is built from shattered pieces of rock and cinders. [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals.]	*Cinder cone volcano.*	[Teacher listens carefully. All students respond correctly.]	Great. And what type has layers of lava and ash? [Pause.] Everyone? [Teacher signals.] *Composite volcano.* Yes, now you've got all fthree types.

Researchers have identified numerous benefits of choral responses (Heward, 1997; Kamps, Dugan, Leonard, & Daost, 1994). The foremost benefit is that *all* students are involved, not just one. Thus the opportunities for each child to respond are increased. Because of the efficiency of choral responses, the number of responses requested can also be increased. Next, using choral responses is a very safe procedure for shy students, reluctant students, students with learning challenges, or students initially learning English (or any second language). Similarly, many of us feel more comfortable singing in a choir than singing a solo. Next, there is built-in support (scaffolding) for struggling students: They hear the answer and can join in, and also receive immediate feedback on the accuracy of their responses. Finally, you receive instant feedback on your students' knowledge as you listen to their responses.

Like an orchestra director creating beautiful music, you must direct your students so that they will say answers together. Some type of signal—either an **auditory signal** (e.g., a vocal command ["Everyone?"], a tap, a clap, or a snap) or a **visual hand signal**—must be adopted, taught to students, and consistently used. You can use any signal you choose, as long as it allows you to regulate the amount of thinking time given to students and cues them when to say the answer. You might find the signals outlined in Figure 6.2 helpful.

Teachers often identify a number of challenges with choral responses, including the student who mouths the words or does not respond at all, or the student who disregards the signal and "blurts out" the answer, therefore robbing classmates of the chance to formulate an answer (Hunter, 1982). The teacher's response is the same in each case: "Let's say that again." This gives the reluctant student a chance to say the answer the second time and can put peer pressure on the blurter to cease and desist.

A challenge with all responses is gauging the amount of thinking time that students need. If adequate time is not provided, students may be rushed into guessing, and errors will occur. One way to predict the amount of thinking time needed is to process the answer as students are processing it. Perhaps you are asking whether 5 is a prime number. In your head, you might say: "Okay, 5 is divisible by 5 and 1 but isn't divisible by any other number, so 5 is a prime number." By processing the answer yourself, you will find yourself giving students more thinking time. Another way to judge the amount of thinking time needed is to have students indicate when they have determined the answer. In elementary classes, you might have students put up a thumb to indicate that they have formulated an answer. In secondary classes, you can have students make eye contact with you to indicate that they have processed the answer. We do *not* recommend that students raise their hands to indicate having an answer, because this practice has a number of negative consequences. Some students who have not thought of the answer will raise their hands upon seeing the first hand go up, to save face with their peers.

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FIGURE 6.2. Suggested signals for choral responses.

Situation	Signal/cue for choral response
Students are looking at the teacher.	1. The teacher asks a question and raises his or her hands. 2. The teacher gives students thinking time. 3. The teacher then lowers his or her hands and says, "Everyone?" 4. Students say the answer together.
Students are looking at a common stimulus, such as a word on the board, a location on a map, a step on a strategy poster, a picture in the big book, or a number on the overhead transparency.	1. The teacher points at the stimulus. 2. The teacher asks a question. 3. The teacher provides thinking time. 4. The teacher then taps next to the stimulus and says, "Everyone?" 5. Students say the answer together.
Students are looking at a worksheet, a page in a textbook, or a handout.	1. The teacher asks a question or gives a directive. 2. The teacher provides thinking time. 3. The teacher then invites students to say an answer, using a vocal command such as "Everyone?" 4. Students say the answer together.

Other students, upon seeing the first hand go up, give a sigh of relief and don't even try to think of an answer, thus totally abdicating to the hand-waving student. When the majority of students have indicated that they have an answer, the teacher signals for a response.

Some general guidelines can be followed for thinking time, no matter what type of response is requested. When you are asking a lower-cognitive-demand question, in which students must recall material recently read or taught, 3 seconds are generally adequate for thinking time. When you are asking a higher-cognitive-demand question, in which students must manipulate several logical arguments or information previously learned in order to create an answer, longer thinking time leads to more engagement, higher-quality answers, longer responses, and more variety in responses (Cotton, 2001). If students are repeating a short response you have modeled, an immediate signal for a response can be given—for example, "This word is *was*. What word? [Immediate signal] *Was*."

Another challenge in using choral responses is the difficulty of discerning individual errors embedded within the choral response (Heward et al., 1989). When a student within the group makes an error, it may be difficult to implement individual correction procedures. Two practices can alleviate this difficulty. First, when an error occurs, instead of delivering a correction to the individual, you can implement the correction procedure with the entire group, thereby strengthening the learning of all students. Second, at the end of a choral response sequence, you can check the understanding of individuals by calling on a number of students. In fact,

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one study found that interspersing individual questions during choral responding led to increased responding, increased accuracy, and decreased disruptive behavior of those students most reluctant to participate, thus strengthening the effects of the choral responding procedure (Armendariz, 2005).

Partner Responses

Perhaps, one of the most effective ways to engage students is to have them share answers with their partners. Whether the answer is short or long, but particularly when the wording is long and the answers vary, students can turn to their partners and share their answers. Like choral responses, partner responses benefit both teachers and students. Once again, *all* children are involved as they either say the answer or listen to their partners' responses. Students also benefit from the richness of their partners' ideas, which often spark new ideas and perspectives in turn. Students receive feedback from their partners as well: If any answers are incorrect or incomplete, their partners can gently correct them or add to the answers. If they are not certain what the question is, partners can inform them. Partner work is also a fertile venue for building language proficiency, social skills, and cooperation skills, as well as for developing a community of learners in the classroom. Finally, students have an opportunity to interact socially, which is a major goal of intermediate and secondary students. This social interaction makes the lesson more pleasurable and fun for students.

Partner responses have great benefits for you, the teacher. As students are sharing answers, you can move around the room and listen to numerous responses, receiving information on your teaching not just from one student but from many. Consequently, you are able to provide feedback—whether it is acknowledgment, encouragement, or corrections—to numerous students. Partner time also gives you an opportunity to coach lower-performing students. As soon as you direct students to share with their partners, you can move around the room and coach struggling students, helping them formulate answers that are accurate and complete.

You can make the use of partner responses more effective by following a few guidelines. First, it is best if you select the partners. Children will tend to pick a partner like themselves, not always the best classroom match. When you are selecting partners, place the lowest-performing students with middle-performing students rather than with the highest-performing students. The middle-performing students will tend to be more supportive, allowing the lower-performing students more opportunities to respond. Next, have the partners sit next to each other (rather than across from each other at a table) and assign a designation to each partner, such as "One" or "Two." Once you have assigned numbers, you can request one student in each pair to say the answer ("Ones, tell your partner . . . " or "Twos, tell your partner . . . "), thus distributing opportunities to respond across classmates. It is often useful to give the higher-performing student in each partnership the "One" designation, so that this student can model for the other partner (e.g., "Ones, using

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your graphic organizer, teach your partner what we learned about the branches of the federal government," then "Twos, teach your partner").

One procedure for selecting partners for literacy instruction involves these steps (Fuchs, Mathes, & Fuchs, 1996):

1. Determine the oral reading fluency (correct oral words per minute) of each child. Have each child orally read a passage to you for 1 minute, and then calculate the number of words read correctly in a minute.
2. Rank the children from lowest to highest in fluency.
3. Cut the list in half and line up the two halves. The result is that the lowest-performing students will be paired with middle-performing students.
4. Use your knowledge of your students to adjust the partnerships so that students will work well together.

A few other practices can help you to make optimal use of partners. Perhaps students are taught in three different locations in your classroom: at their desks for whole-group instruction, at the "rug area" for whole-group instruction, and at a table for small-group instruction. In this case, assign students partners at their desks and the numbers One and Two. When they come to the rug, have them sit next to their partners and use the same numbers. But because small-group instruction generally involves homogeneous grouping, different partners will be needed. To facilitate assigning partners at the small-group table, tape index cards on the table announcing each student's number with an arrow pointing to the partner. It is also important to change the partnerships—not on a daily basis, but perhaps every 3–6 weeks. Also, teaching students how to be partners is essential. Teach a strategy such as **Look, lean, and whisper** ("Look at your partner, lean toward your partner, and whisper the answer to your partner"), or teach desired partnership behaviors by using a "Looks like/Sounds like" chart (see Chapter 5, Figure 5.6).

Finally, when you are asking students to share answers with their partners, it is helpful to give them a **sentence starter.** For example, after the reading of a paragraph in a content area book, this directive might be given:

> Review the paragraph and determine the main idea. [Teacher pauses and provides thinking time.] Ones, tell your partner the main idea of the paragraph. Begin by saying, "The main idea is . . . ` "

There are several benefits of providing a sentence starter: The students will initiate their responses more quickly, utilize full sentences to express their answers, and be more likely to stay on topic. In addition, stating the sentence starter often helps in the cognitive retrieval and formulation of the answer.

Although there are many ways that partners can be used in classes, we are going to share a few practices that we have found particularly successful: (1) **Think–**

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Pair–Share, (2) **Think and Write–Pair and Write–Share**, (3) the **Pause** procedure, and (4) **Study–Tell–Help–Check**.

THINK–PAIR–SHARE

One of the simplest ways to utilize partners is to use a procedure developed by Frank T. Lyman, Jr. (Lyman, 1981; McTighe & Lyman, 1988): **Think–Pair–Share**. The procedure has two emphases: (1) giving students time to think before responding, and (2) directing students to say answers to their partners instead of calling on one student (e.g., "Think: What will happen next in the story? Twos, tell your partner"). Having students share answers with partners is particularly useful when the answers are long and the wording varies, making choral responses impossible. When you are using **Think–Pair–Share**, follow these steps:

1. **Think**. Ask a question and provide thinking time.
2. **Pair**. Ask students to pair up and communicate their ideas to their partners.
3. **Share**. Call on a number of students to share with the class. Or, if the answer is short and the wording is the same, have all students say the answer, or tell students the answers you have heard while circulating and monitoring.

The lesson segments in Figure 6.3 illustrate the varied uses of **Think–Pair–Share**. As you examine these lesson segments, attend to the use of partner responses and the feedback given to students.

THINK AND WRITE–PAIR AND WRITE–SHARE

In many situations, students need to brainstorm ideas related to a topic. For example, students may brainstorm ideas for an essay, uses of perimeter measures, benefits of a particular learning strategy, common causes of war, examples of renewable and nonrenewable resources, or additional words with the base *auto*. Just a few modifications to **Think–Pair–Share** can make it a viable brainstorming procedure. First, have students **think and write** down their ideas, thus increasing accountability and allowing you to monitor their responses, which is impossible if they are only "thinking." Next, when students **pair** up to communicate their ideas, have each student **write** down the partner's best ideas. If you occasionally ask students to share their partners' best ideas, they will feel more accountable for listening to their partners. While students complete the **Think and Write** and **Pair and Write** steps, move around the room and record their ideas and their names on an overhead transparency (or piece of paper, if a document camera is used). Then use this list of ideas during the **Share** step, which makes the sharing more efficient than the usual time-consuming practice of calling on individual students.

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THE PAUSE PROCEDURE

The **Pause** procedure is perfect for illustrating the power of active participation at any grade level. This procedure was researched with learning-disabled and non-learning-disabled students in college classes with a traditional lecture format (Ruhl, Hughes, & Gajar, 1990; Ruhl, Hughes, & Schloss, 1987). As all of us have experienced, it is difficult to listen to any lecturer for a sustained period of time. In these studies, the instructor lectured for 12–18 minutes and then paused for 2 minutes, during which students worked in pairs to discuss the lecture and rework their notes. This simple procedure resulted in significantly higher retention of lecture content (as measured by free-recall quizzes and comprehension tests) for these college students, including those with learning disabilities. Johnson, Johnson, and Smith (1991) have suggested a reflective pause of 3–4 minutes, during which students can summarize the lecture segment, answer a focus question, predict what will be covered next in the lecture, and share their own experiences.

STUDY–TELL–HELP–CHECK

We suggest using an active participation procedure that is similar to the **Pause** procedure. **Study–Tell–Help–Check** can be used at the beginning of a class to review previously taught content, at the end of class to review the day's lesson, or intermittently during the lesson. Using this procedure, the teacher gives students an opportunity to **study** their notes, handout, or textbook for a short period of time (e.g., 1–2 minutes). The teacher then directs one member of each partnership to **tell** the other partner all they remember about the topic without consulting any reference materials. Their partners **help** them out by asking them questions, giving them hints, or telling them any missing information. When both partners in each pair have exhausted their recall of the information, they look back at their handouts or textbooks to **check** their responses and to locate any missing information. Like the **Pause** procedure, the use of **Study–Tell–Help–Check** throughout a lesson helps students feel more accountable for their learning, and the rehearsal and retrieval also help them retain more information. Examine the lesson segments in Figure 6.4 to see the use of these procedures in varying situations.

You can use partners in many other ways as well. Partners can read to each other, explain a process by using an example, teach the content of a graphic organizer to each other, dictate spelling words and provide feedback on spelling accuracy, edit each other's work, help each other stay on task, collect materials for an absent partner, assist during independent work time, and study material together. The uses are endless, and the benefits are great. In the lesson provided in Figure 6.5, identify how the teacher uses partner responses.

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FIGURE 6.3. Lesson segments: **Think–Pair–Share.**

Lesson segment 1: Kindergarten reading				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
[Teacher has read aloud *Wolf* by Becky Bloom (1999).]	Think. . . . "What surprised you the most in *Wolf?* [Pause for 5 seconds.]	[Students think about answer.]		
	First Ones, then Twos, tell your partner what surprised you the most.	[Students tell their partners what surprised them in the story.]	[Teacher moves around the room, monitoring and coaching.]	
	Adam, what surprised you the most?	*Well, on the first page of the story the wolf was very hungry, but it didn't eat until the last page.*	[Teacher listens to Adam's answer.]	Everyone, raise your hand if that surprised you, too. I agree. It surprised me that the starving wolf didn't eat until the picnic.
	Bethany, what surprised you? [Teacher calls on two other students.]			Wow, what good thinkers you are!
Lesson segment 2: Fifth-grade math				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
[Students have been studying decimals for 2 weeks.]				

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On the board: .4 .40 .400	Read these numbers with me. Everyone?	*Four tenths, forty hundredths, four hundred thousandths.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	Great.
	Think. Are these decimals equivalent or not? Be ready to explain your thinking to your partner. Write down information that you can use in your explanation. [Teacher gives students abundant thinking time.]	[Students think about the fractions, recording notes as needed.]	[Teacher moves around the room, watching to see that each student is recording ideas.]	
	Ones, tell your partner if the decimals are equivalent or not, and explain your answer.	[Students pair up and explain their answers to their partners.]	[Teacher moves around the room, listening to explanations and ready to reteach the concept if students are inaccurate or confused.]	[Teacher provides affirmative feedback to partnerships.]
	Everyone, are the decimals equivalent? [Teacher signals.]	*Yes.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	Yes, these are equivalent.
	Elizabeth, please share your explanation.	*I changed the decimals into fractions: 4/10, 40/100, and 400/1000. I could reduce both 40/100 and 400/1000 to 4/10 so I knew the decimals were equivalent.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	Excellent. You really used what we have learned about the relationship between fractions and decimals.
	Drew, share your explanation.	*I know that you can remove zeros at the end of a decimal without changing its value. So I crossed off the zeros, and all of the decimals were four-tenths.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	Yes, you can remove the zeros at the *end* of a decimal and not change the value. Class, look at this decimal: .400. If I cross out the zeros, have I changed the value? *No.* Look at this decimal: .004. If I cross out the zeros, will I change the value? *Yes.*

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FIGURE 6.4. Lesson segments: Partner procedures.

Lesson segment 1: Fourth-grade writing lesson using Think and Write–Pair and Write–Share				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
[Yesterday, the students each selected a holiday to write a report about.] In preparation for researching your holiday, we have to determine the topics that might be covered. We need to narrow down the topics so you can cover a few in depth.	First, tell your partner the holiday that you are going to write about.	[Students tell partners the name of their chosen holiday.]		
	Now we are going to brainstorm general topics that all of you might address in your report. For example, we could all determine the history of our holiday. We could also investigate any special foods associated with our holiday. [Teacher writes *history* and *foods* on overhead transparency.] I could write a paragraph or more about either of these topics. Now, on your paper, write some other general topics that could be explored for any given holiday.	[Students write down possible topics.]	[Teacher moves around the room, writing down topics and corresponding student names on a overhead transparency.]	[Teacher gives corrective feedback if the topic could not generate at least a paragraph or is unrelated to the study of holidays.]
	Ones, then Twos, read your list to your partner. If your partner has a topic that you might cover in your report, add it to your list.	[Students read their lists to their partners and record excellent ideas from their partners' lists.]	[Teacher continues to move around the room, recording topics on the overhead transparency.]	[Teacher continues to provide acknowledgment, praise, and corrective feedback.] Look up here. Let's read the list of topics that you generated: *History*

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				Foods *Special decorations* (*Sylvia*) *Presents or prizes* (*Sean*) *Significance* (*Pedro*) *Special clothing* (*Freda*) *Where observed* (*Jason*)
Lesson segment 2: Eighth-grade science using Study–Tell–Help–Check				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
[Students have just begun a unit on electricity and are viewing page 55 is their textbooks.]	**Study** Students, you will have 2 minutes to study page 55. Be ready to tell your partner about sources of electricity. **Tell** Twos, tell your partner what you remember about sources of electricity. Ones, help them out.	**Study** [Students study page 55.] **Tell** Partner Two: *This section was talking about producing energy in power plants. It said that burning coal could be transformed into electricity.* **Help** Partner One: *What other fuels can be used to generate electricity?* Partner Two: *Oh, yeah, fossil fuels . . . and nuclear energy.* Partner One: *Don't forget about the force of moving water. Let's check the book.* **Check** [Students look over page 55.] Partner One: *We forgot about the alternative sources, like solar energy and energy from the wind or tidal waves that can be used to generate electricity.*	[Teacher moves around the classroom and observes.] [During the **Tell, Help,** and **Check** steps, teacher moves from partnership to partnership, listening carefully to students' responses.]	[Teacher reinforces on-task behavior with private praise.] [Teacher reinforces on-task behavior, cooperative behavior, and correct information.]

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FIGURE 6.5. Partner responses in a lesson.

Sixth-grade writing				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
We have been learning how to expand sentences to make them more interesting and informative. Today we are going to add words and phrases to our sentences to tell *when* something happens.				
Shown on overhead: *Charles arrived at the office. From this first sentence, we have no idea when Charles arrived.*	*Read this sentence with me. Charles arrived at the office.*	*Charles arrived at the office.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	
Shown on overhead: *Before dawn, Charles arrived at the office.*	Now, read the new sentence with me. *Before dawn, Charles arrived at the office.*	*Before dawn, Charles arrived at the office.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	
	Ones, tell your partner the phrase that tells *when* Charles arrived at the office.	*Before dawn*.	[Teacher moves around room and listens to partners.]	
	Everyone, when did Charles arrive at the office?	*Before dawn*.	[Teacher listens carefully.]	Yes, before dawn. Now we know when Charles arrived. Notice that the phrase at the beginning of the sentence is followed by a comma.
Shown on overhead: *Charles arrived at the office just after lunch.*	Read the new sentence with me. *Charles arrived at the office just after lunch.*	*Charles arrived at the office just after lunch.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	
	Twos, tell your partner the phrase that tells *when* Charles arrived at the office.	*Just after lunch.*	[Teacher moves around room and listens to partners.]	The phrase that tells when is *just after lunch*. Notice that at the end of the sentence, a comma is not used to separate the phrase from rest of the sentence.

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Shown on overhead: Yesterday, Charles arrived at the office.	Read the new sentence with me. *Yesterday, Charles arrived at the office.*	*Yesterday, Charles arrived at the office.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	
	Everyone, what word tells *when* Charles arrived at the office? [Teacher signals.]	*Yesterday.*	[Teacher listens carefully to answers. All students respond correctly.]	*Yesterday.* Here a word that tells when, rather than a phrase, was added to make the sentence more interesting and informative.
Shown on overhead: *The train pulled into the station.*	Read the sentence with me. *The train pulled into the station.*	*The train pulled into the station.*	[Teacher listens carefully.]	
	On your paper, write down words or phrases that could tell *when* the train pulled into the station. For example, you might write *this morning* or *one winter afternoon.* [Teacher writes these phrases on the overhead.] Continue writing words or phrases until I tell you to stop.	[Students write down possible words or phrases that would tell when the train might pull into the station.]	[Teacher moves around the room, examining papers, providing verbal feedback to students, and writing down accurate words or phrases and corresponding student names on the overhead transparency.]	
	First Ones, then Twos, read your list to your partner. If your partner has a great idea, add it to your list.	[Students read lists to partners and add new ideas to their lists.]	[Teacher continues to move around the room, writing down ideas and names on the overhead transparency.]	You had many words and phrases that would really add to the sentence. Let's read some of your classmates' ideas. [Teacher and students read the following list:] *One morning* (*Tracy*) *At dusk* (*Sean*) *Before the scheduled time* (*Grace*) *Right at noon* (*Kendal*) *Yesterday* (*Marcus*) *At 6:03 as scheduled* (*Diego*) *Three days late* (*Mary Lee*) *After being gone 2 weeks* (*Nash*)

(cont.)

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FIGURE 6.5. *(cont.)*

Input →	Question →	Response →	Monitor →	Feedback
				In the late afternoon (*Jenn*) *Before the whistle sounded* (*Marta*)
	Now circle your best *when* word or phrase. [Pause.]	[Students circle the best *when* word or phrase.]	[Teacher circulates and monitors choices.]	
	Now write your sentence. If you put your phrase at the beginning of the sentence, remember to put a comma after the phrase.	[Students write sentences.]	[Teacher moves around the room and writes a number of sentences on a transparency.]	
	Read your sentence to your partner.	[Students read sentences to their partners.]	[Teacher moves from partnership to partnership, listening to answers and writing down sentences.]	Let's read some of your classmates' sentences. *At 7:30, the train pulled into the station.* (*Kevin*) *As the clock struck 6:00, the train pulled into the station.* (*Anne Maria*) *The train pulled into the station before we arrived at the gate.* (*Troy*) Notice that the *when* phrases make the sentences much more interesting.
Shown on overhead: *Chad entered the city library.*	Read this sentence with me. *Chad entered the city library.*	*Chad entered the city library.*		
	Write this sentence, adding a *when* word or phrase.	[Students write edited sentence.]	[Teacher circulates and writes down sentences.]	
	Read your sentence to your partner.	[Students read their sentences to their partners.]	[Teacher moves around the room and listens to sentences.]	Let's listen to some of your classmates' sentences. [Teacher Calls on individuals.]

Team Responses

In some cases, you may wish two partnerships to join together to form a cooperative team, or you may wish to use teams of four exclusively for responding in your classroom. Partner and team responses are both elements of **cooperative learning**, which is described by Johnson, Johnson, and Holubec (1993) as "the instructional use of small groups so that students work together to maximize their own and each other's learning" (p. 6). When you are forming teams, select students of different abilities, ethnicity, and gender, and give each member a number. If you are using both pairs and teams in a class, give students the number One or Two in their partnerships and the designation A, B, C, or D on their teams. Many activity structures (e.g., Kagan, 1989, 1992) have been developed for use by cooperative teams, but one, Numbered Heads Together, has a particularly strong research base (e.g., Maheady, Mallette, Harper, & Sacca, 1991; Maheady, Michielli-Pendl, Harper, & Mallette, 2006).

NUMBERED HEADS TOGETHER

When you are using **Numbered Heads Together** (Kagan, 1989, 1992), place students on teams and give each person in a team either a number or a letter designation. Then pose a question and ask students to "put their heads together" to come up with an answer. Have students continue their discussion until all team members are confident of the answer and feel prepared to share it with the whole class. Then randomly call out a number or a letter; the student in each group with that number or letter becomes the spokesperson for the group. To randomize the number you call out, and to increase student motivation, you can use a spinner or roll a die.

Over time, cooperative learning with its many activity structures has grown in popularity, often resulting in less direct instruction being provided to students. As a result, numerous researchers caution that cooperative learning must always be integrated with explicit instruction and not used as the sole method of instruction (Andersen, Nelson, Fox, & Gruber, 1988; Slavin, Madden, & Leavey, 1984). If students are asked to engage in cooperative learning activities before adequate information has been provided and strategy modeling has occurred, error rates will be high, and students will experience failure and frustration.

Individual Oral Responses

Although choral, partner, and team oral responses are excellent procedures for engaging all students, sometimes you want to call on an individual student to verify his or her learning. Before we examine best practices for calling on individual students, let's discuss some very common procedures that need to be minimized in teaching.

The most common form of teacher questioning is to call on volunteers (Brophy & Good, 1986). That is, the teacher asks a question; requests students to raise their

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hands and volunteer; and then calls on one of the eager, hand-waving students. When this practice is used, the highest-performing, most assertive, and most English-proficient students are most likely to be called on (Maheady et al., 1991). As a result, the teacher ends up "teaching the best and leaving the rest." The practice of calling on volunteers should be limited, so that *all* students can be engaged in the lesson. A simple guideline can be applied: When the answer comes from information that you have presented or from material that students have read, don't invite students to volunteer, because all students should be expected to have an answer. However, if the answer has its genesis in students' own experiential backgrounds, request that students volunteer for responding. This practice of only calling on volunteers when the answer comes from students' personal background knowledge or experiences significantly reduces the number of volunteer responses requested in a lesson.

Another practice that should be minimized (if not avoided altogether) is calling on students when they are inattentive. The time to call on a student is not when the student is rummaging through a backpack or lunging for a purse. In this case, there is little likelihood of getting a sterling answer that adds to the class discourse. Most often teachers call on inattentive students in order to guide them back to the lesson. However, there are better ways to bring them back into the fold without calling on them, including (1) moving closer to an inattentive student; (2) giving a directive to the whole group (e.g., "I need everyone looking up here"); or (3) giving students something physical to do (e.g., "Put your finger on the heading," "Write a heading on your paper," "Draw a T-chart on your paper").

If you are not going to ask for volunteers or call on inattentive students, what are your alternatives? Let's examine three alternatives: **Partners First**, **Question First**, and **Whip Around or Pass**.

PARTNERS FIRST

One procedure for calling on individuals is first to have students share the answer with their partners, and then to call on students randomly to share an answer. You might notice that this takes us right back to **Think–Pair–Share**. When sharing with partners occurs before an individual is called on, the answer will often be of higher quality: Students have had a chance to think, to rehearse their answers, and to receive feedback from their partners (and perhaps from the teacher), all of which will help them develop and refine their answers.

QUESTION FIRST

In some cases, you may choose not to have students share with their partners first. Another possibility is to ask a question, give everyone thinking time, and then randomly call on a student. It is important to note that you ask the question, provide thinking time, and **then** call on the student, rather than saying the student's name first and then conveying the question. If the name is mentioned first, the remaining

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students in the class are less likely to listen to the question, think of an answer, or attend to their classmate's answer.

One challenge when calling on individual students is that you may tend to favor some students, calling on them often and other students seldom or never. To ensure that all students are involved in lessons, you need to have a plan for distributing the individual responses. One possibility is to write each student's name on a card and place the cards in a container. During the lesson, draw a name and call on that student. Another possible practice is to divide the room into sections (in your own mind) and call on students in different sections of the room. Using either of these practices will broaden the distribution of responses in the classroom.

Another challenge when calling on individuals occurs when a student responds, "I don't know," or "I don't remember." When a teacher receives these responses, the teacher often calls on other students until finding someone with a correct answer. Unfortunately, the teacher may be inadvertently teaching students that it is perfectly acceptable not to have an answer, resulting in a viral epidemic of "I don't knows" rushing through the classroom. Instead of going on a "fishing expedition," you need viable alternatives that go beyond the fruitless action of repeating the question in a louder voice. When a student cannot give an answer, you can support the student and scaffold the response through a number of practices, which include (1) breaking the task down into easier segments and guiding the student in its completion by asking questions; (2) allowing the student to confer with a partner while you call on other students, but then returning to the first student for the newly generated answer; (3) guiding the student in referring back to the textbook, handout, assignment, or notes to locate the answer; (4) asking the student to comment on the answers that have been given by peers; or (5) simply telling the student the answer and having him or her repeat it.

WHIP AROUND OR PASS

In some situations, it is appropriate for you to have students take turns responding. For example, in **Whip Around or Pass** (Harmin, 1994), you can go up and down rows rapidly and have students contribute with no intervening comments by you or their classmates. Tell students to say "Pass" when they don't have a response or their answer has already been suggested. This method for calling on individuals is particularly useful when there are many possible answers and the answers are derived from students' personal background knowledge. For example, **Whip Around or Pass** works well with directives such as these:

1. "Tell your favorite food. **Whip Around or Pass**."
2. "We are making a pie graph concerning favorite pets. Be ready to tell your favorite pet. **Whip Around or Pass**."
3. "We have just learned the vocabulary term *compulsory*. Get ready to tell something that is *compulsory* at this school. **Whip Around or Pass**."

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As with all active participation practices, providing thinking time before you ask for responses will increase your students' confidence and the quality of their answers. You might have students write their ideas down before beginning **Whip Around or Pass.**

Written Responses

In many subjects, students are asked to produce written responses during lessons. For example, teachers dictate spelling words for students to write. In math classes, teachers display problems on a blackboard or SMART Board and have students solve them. In writing lessons, students brainstorm and record possible arguments to be used in persuasive essays.

Though requesting written responses in a lesson appears to be a simple procedure, problems can emerge. First, some students write answers very quickly, whereas others take an inordinate amount of time to write the same response. As a result, early finishers are left waiting for their classmates to finish—and, as we have all experienced, when there is a void, students will fill it. To avoid unproductive waiting time, it is helpful to construct lesson activities so that students are engaged in written responses for a brief amount of time. (This is not necessary during independent work sessions.) For example, when you are teaching a math lesson, it is better to have students complete one problem with immediate feedback than six items before receiving corrective feedback. The amount of student waiting time and the number of emergent behavioral challenges will be reduced; simultaneously, student success will be increased because of the immediacy of feedback and additional instructional input.

Another challenge with written responses occurs when students have a worksheet or textbook assignment in front of them. Often a few students will proceed ahead of the others; instead of doing Item 1 as directed and waiting for feedback, these students do Items 2, 3, and 4. Unfortunately, the "sneakers" may make errors because they are not attending to the teacher's input or feedback. These early finishers may also create a disturbance by boasting about their item completion. Simple procedures can reduce the challenge of the "sneakers." Give a directive: "When you are done, put your pencil down and look up," or "When you are done, turn your paper over." One of these practices, along with careful monitoring, is usually all that is needed to encourage students to stay with you during the lesson.

Response Cards and Response Slates

When we think of written responses, we generally envision students writing on paper, but many other options are available for reviewing and practicing information. These include the use of **response cards** and **response slates**.

When **response cards** are used, teachers give students a limited set of preprinted cards or have students prepare their own set of cards by writing possible

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answers on the cards (under the teachers' guidance). Possible answers include true or false; yes or no; A, B, C, or D; agree or disagree; or content-specific answers. For example, primary students may have letter cards on their desks. The teacher says a sound, and students display the matching letter. In English class, students may have cards with various literary terms (*theme*, *mood*, *moral*, *foreshadowing*, etc.). The teacher asks a question, and students hold up the correct card. In science, students can be given cards with terms for three types of volcanoes (*shield volcanoes*, *composite volcanoes*, *cinder cone volcanoes*). The teacher describes a volcano or asks a question about it, and students display the corresponding card. Similarly, the librarian may use response cards labeled *title page*, *copyright page*, *glossary*, *table of contents*, and *index* to review reference materials found within an expository textbook.

When **response slates** are used, teachers ask questions, and students record their responses on a small whiteboard or slate or plastic sleeve protector (with cardboard insert). Reading teachers can dictate sounds or words and have students record the corresponding letter or written word. Math teachers can have students complete a problem on their slates and display the completed problem. A social studies or science teacher can pose a question and scan the written answers of all students.

For both response cards and response slates, you ask a question and provide thinking time, and then the students hold up their answers (on either cards or slates) for your inspection. You can then monitor all student responses and respond as needed: correct errors, clarify misperceptions, reteach information, or move forward in the lesson. The use of response cards and slates has been proven to benefit students and teachers across a variety of age groups and subject areas by (1) increasing for each student the opportunities to respond, (2) increasing the number of students participating in the lesson, (3) increasing the academic achievement of students, and (4) decreasing off-task and disruptive behavior (e.g., Armendariz & Umbreit, 1997; Cavanaugh et al., 1996; Christle & Schuster, 2003; Heward et al., 1996; Lambert, Cartledge, Heward, & Lo, 2006; Maheady, Michielli-Pendl, Mallette, & Harper, 2002; Narayan, Heward, Gardner, Courson, & Omness, 1990; Randolph, 2007; Skinner et al., 1996).

Whether you use response cards or response slates will depend upon what you are trying to accomplish during a particular lesson. With response cards, students have a limited field of answers to select from rather than all possible responses, and many quick responses can be requested until students have a very firm grasp of the concepts or information. Response cards are an excellent choice when the number of potential answers is limited. On the other hand, you may choose response slates when answers are longer, more divergent, or more dependent upon personal preferences or experiences.

After examining the lesson segments in Figure 6.6, think of other situations where the use of response cards or response slates could enrich the lesson.

(text resumes on page 158)

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FIGURE 6.6. Lesson segments: Response slate and response card usage.

Lesson segment 1: Spelling lesson in resource room using response slates				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
[This is the second day of instruction on dropping the *e* when adding a suffix that begins with a vowel.]				
On the board: *ride + ing* *excite + ment* *excite + ed* *fame + ous* *refuse + al* *use + ing* *use + ful* *race + ist*	Get your slates out. [Pause.] Yesterday, we learned that when a word ends in vowel–consonant–final *e* and you want to add a suffix that begins with a vowel, you should _____. Everyone? [Teacher signals.]	*Drop the e.*	[Teacher listens to responses. All are correct.]	Yes, when the word ends in an *e* and we want to add an ending that begins with a vowel, we drop the *e*.
	Let's do one together. Everyone, does *ride end in a vowel–consonant–final e*? [Teacher signals.]	*Yes.*	[Teacher listens to responses.]	[Teacher moves on.]
	Everyone, does the suffix begin with a vowel? [Teacher signals.]	*Yes.*	[Teacher listens to responses.]	[Teacher moves on.]
	So do we need to drop the *e*? [Teacher signals.]	*Yes.*		
	Write the word *riding* on your slate. [Pause.]	[Students write *riding* on slates.]	[Teacher walks around and monitors.]	
	Hold up your slates.	[Students hold up slates.]	[Teacher glances at the slates. All students are correct.]	Good. You dropped the *e* before adding *ing*. [Teacher writes *riding on the board.]*
	Next, we have *excite + ment*. Write *excitement* on your slates. [Pause.]	[Students write *excitement* on slates.]	[Teacher walks around and monitors.]	

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	Hold up your slates.	[Students hold up slates.]	[Teacher glances at slates. Numerous students have written the word incorrectly as *excitment*.]	Let's look at this one together. [Teacher guides students in applying the rule.] Does *excite* end in a vowel–consonant–*e*? *Yes.* Does the suffix begin with a vowel? *No.* So do we drop the *e*? *No.* [Teacher writes *excitement* on the board.] If you made an error, erase and write *excitement.* Show me your slates. [Later in the lesson, students are again asked to write *excitement.*]
Lesson segment 2: Third-grade math using response slates				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
[Students have been taught six shapes: circle, square, rectangle, triangle, hexagon, pentagon.]	Let's review shapes. Get out your slates. [Pause.] Write down the number of sides in a rectangle. [Pause.] Hold up your slates.	[Students write 4 on their slates.]	[Teacher examines responses on slates. All students are correct.]	Yes, a rectangle has four sides.
	Ones, tell your partner what else we know about rectangles.	*They are closed figures. The sides are straight lines.*	[Teacher walks around and listens to a number of partnerships.]	Great. I heard that rectangles are closed figures with straight lines and four sides.
	Now draw rectangles on your slates. Keep drawing rectangles until I tell you to stop. Make them different sizes. [Pause.]	[Students draw rectangles on their slates.]	[Teacher walks around the room and looks at rectangles.]	
	Hold up your slates.	[Students hold them up.]	[Teacher examines slates. All shapes are rectangles.]	All of your rectangles are closed figures with four sides. Good. Let's try some more difficult shapes.
[Teacher continues in the same way with the remaining shapes.]		[Students continue to show appropriate shapes.]		

(cont.)

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FIGURE 6.6. *(cont.)*

Lesson segment 3: Seventh-grade language arts using response cards				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
Sentence on the board: *Jeff cryed out, stop! The table will brake under the wait of that box.*	Look over the sentence and count the number of errors. [Pause.] Show me the number with your fingers.	[Students hold up between three and seven fingers.]	[Teacher looks carefully at number of fingers.]	There are six errors in this sentence. Let's find the errors.
Class members review the sentence, holding up the corresponding response card: *no error* *spelling error* *capital* *period (.)* *question mark (?)* *exclamation mark (!)* *comma (,)* *quotation marks (" ")*	[Teacher points to *Jeff* in the sentence.] Get ready to hold up the card or cards. [Pause.] Hold up your card.	[Students hold up *no error.*]	[Teacher examines response cards.]	Excellent. There are no errors here. Tell your partner why *Jeff* is capitalized. [Teacher listens to a number of partner responses.] Yes, *Jeff* is a proper name, and it is also the first word in the sentence.
	[Teacher points to *cryed and pauses for a few seconds.] Hold up your card.*	*[Most students hold up spelling error.* However, a number of students hold up *no error.*]	[Teacher looks carefully at response cards.]	*Cryed is not spelled correctly. Let's review the spelling rule. When a word ends in a consonant and a y, and we add a suffix that begins with any vowel except i*, what should we do? [Teacher signals.] *Change the y to an i.* Spell *cried* as I rewrite the word. *c-r-i-e-d.* [Teacher crosses out *cryed* on the board and writes *cried*.]
	[Teacher continues in the same manner through the remainder of the sentence.]		[Teacher looks carefully at response cards.]	[For errors, teacher leads students to the correct answer, as above.]

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Lesson segment 4: High school chemistry using response cards				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
On the SMART Board: 1. *An element's atomic number is the same as its* *a. number of electrons* *b. number of protons* *c. number of neutrons*	Let's review what we learned yesterday. Read Item 1 on the SMART Board. Pick the best answer and select the best card, a, b, or c.	[Students read Item 1 and select response card.]	[Teacher walks around and monitors responses.]	
	Please compare your answer with your partner's answer. [Pause.] Show me your answers.	[Students compare answers with partners, and then hold up their response cards.]	[Teacher walks around and listens to partners, then looks at response cards.]	Yes. The atomic number is the same as the number of protons. Remember that the periodic chart is organized by the atomic number.
2. *The most abundant element in the universe is* *a. helium* *b. carbon* *c. hydrogen*	Read Item 2. Select the best answer.	[Students read Item 2 and select response card.]		
	Compare your answer with your partner's. If your answers are different, check in your book. [Pause.]	[Students compare answers with partners and start looking in books.]		
	Hold up your cards.	[Students hold up their cards.]	[Teacher examines cards. A number of students have selected *a. helium*.)	The correct answer is *c. hydrogen*. Look at the chart in your book and find out how abundant hydrogen is, then find out how abundant helium is. [Pause.] What did you find for hydrogen? [Teacher calls on an individual to read the number of nuclei per million.] What did you find for helium? [Teacher calls on an individual to read the number of nuclei per million.] Which number is higher? [Teacher calls on an individual to say which number.] So, everyone, which one is the most abundant? [Teacher signals.] *Hydrogen.* Yes, hydrogen is the most abundant element in the universe. Helium is also very abundant but not as abundant, as hydrogen.

Action Responses

We have introduced a number of ways in which students can give both oral and written responses. Of course, students can also respond with a designated action, such as touching or pointing at a stimulus, responding with gestures, giving hand signals, or acting out an answer. Often this type of action response can increase students' interest, attention, and pleasure. Let's examine each of these action responses.

Touching/Pointing

Teachers of primary students and struggling students should constantly ask their students to touch specific items. This request should ring throughout the lesson: "Put your finger on the letter," "Put your finger on the word," Put your finger on the picture," "Put your finger on the heading." This simple response is designed to bring students' attention to the stimulus and to allow the teacher to monitor students to see whether they are at the right place in the text. With struggling students or young students, teachers may also wish to direct partners to verify that their partners are in the right place. A simple directive, such as "put your finger on the first word in the paragraph" followed by "Now check your partner," will increase the number of students who are at the correct place.

Acting Out/Responding with Gestures or Facial Expressions

We recognize that students may act out of their own accord, but we are not referring to that type of "acting out" here. We are referring to *orchestrated* "acting out." Scenery, parts, scripts, and costumes are not necessary. Rather, you can incorporate acting out into a lesson to make it more memorable and interesting to students, regardless of age or grade. For example, as you read a story in kindergarten, you can ask a few members of the class to become the major characters and act out the story events to support all students' comprehension. In a high school English class, you can ask partners to act out vocabulary terms to enhance their memory of the terms. When students are learning the differences among solids, liquids, and gases in a science class, you can have students stand close together with no movement to demonstrate a solid, stand slightly separated with slight movement to illustrate a liquid, and disperse around the room to illustrate a gas. In all cases, the acting out will make the concepts easier to remember.

Similarly, students can respond with simple gestures or facial expressions that will also make the lesson content more vivid. For example, when learning the characteristics of composite volcanoes, you can have students form the base of the volcano with their hands and show the steep sides as they bring their hands to a peak. In math, students can signal which type of operation to perform by forming a plus

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(+) sign, minus (–) sign, or multiplication (×) sign with their arms. When learning the word *furious*, students can demonstrate their knowledge of *furious* versus *not furious* by altering their facial expressions. When learning a specific sound, kindergarten students can put their hands on their heads when they hear the sound. Obviously, the uses of acting out, gestures, and facial expressions are as varied as the settings in which you teach. All that is required is a little creativity to add to the richness of a lesson.

Hand Signals

Another effective unison response procedure is for students to show answers via hand signals (Pratton & Hales, 1986). At the simplest level, students can indicate "yes" with a thumb up, "no" with a thumb down, or "I don't know" with a sideways thumb placement. In addition, any time there are a number of possible answers, students can indicate the answer by holding up a corresponding number of fingers. For example, a social studies teacher writes this on the board:

1. Legislative
2. Executive
3. Judicial

The teacher then asks questions, and students put up the number of fingers that correspond with the answer. Hand signals of this type are particularly useful in reviewing factual information, such as types of rocks (1, igneous; 2, sedimentary; 3, metamorphic), states of matter (1, solid; 2, liquid; 3, gas), types of volcanoes (1, shield; 2, composite; 3, cinder cone); measurements (1, perimeter; 2, area), final punctuation marks (1, period; 2, question mark; 3, exclamation mark), or vocabulary taught for a selection (e.g., 1, *enemy*; 2, *disgusting*; 3, *relieved*; 4, *concentrate*).

The benefits of hand signals are similar to those of response cards and slates: All students are involved, the number of responses requested can be increased, and the teacher can monitor the responses of all students. Although the use of hand signals can be very effective, there is one potential challenge: the hand signal "blurter" who immediately displays an answer, followed by classmates' copying the response, regardless of its accuracy. To reduce this challenge, students can be asked to form the hand signal on their desks or under their chins and then to hold up their hands when requested to do so.

In the lesson segments in Figure 6.7, note how action responses are incorporated into the lessons, and reflect on how you can use these techniques in your teaching.

(text resumes on page 162)

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FIGURE 6.7. Lesson segments: Action responses.

Lesson segment 1: Fifth-grade social studies using hand signals				
Input →	**Question** →	**Response** →	**Monitor** →	**Feedback**
[Students have been studying the branches of the U.S. government, with a recent focus on the Senate and the House of Representatives.]				
On the board: 1. *Senate* 2. *House of Representatives* 3. *Both*	We have been studying the legislative branch of our federal government. Let's review what we know. I am going to give you some information. If I am referring to the Senate, hold up one finger when I request an answer. If I am referring to the House of Representatives, hold up two fingers. In some cases, I will be referring to both the House and the Senate, and you will hold up three fingers. Form your answer under your chin so I can see it, and then hold it up when I ask.			
	First fact. The number of members is based on the population of the state. [Pause.] Show me.	[Students hold up two fingers to indicate House of Representatives.]	[Teacher carefully examines students' hand signals.]	Yes, the number of representatives from each state serving in the House of Representatives varies, because the number is based on the population of the state.

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	Next fact. The Vice President can break a tied vote. [Teacher continues with facts such as these:] Two from every state. (Senate) Two-year term. (House of Representatives) Six-year term. (Senate) Initiates revenue bills. (House) Consents to treaties. (Senate) Elects President if there is a deadlock in the Electoral College. (House) Representatives from states. (Both) Passes laws. (Both) Confirms cabinet secretaries. (Senate) Impeaches officials. (House) Confirms federal judges. (Senate) Presiding officer—Speaker. (House) Members must be U.S. citizens who reside in state. (Both)	[Most students hold up one finger, but other students hold up two or look confused.]	[Teacher examines hand signals and notes that not all students have a firm grasp of this information.]	The Vice President can only vote when necessary to break a tied vote in the Senate. Remember, the Vice President is the ex officio President of the Senate. Although the Vice President seldom actually presides over the Senate, as that role can be given to others, the Vice President can break tied votes in the Senate. [Each time students have errors, teacher tells answer and has them repeat it.] [At the end, teacher repeats all the questions student had errors on.]